at least eight cubs. Officials cite its disappearance as a warning that anything can go wrong and start a downslide in a tiger reserve. The demand from politicians for new reserves is worrying those entrusted with relocation as they know it takes consistent, long-term efforts to prepare a habitat that can be a permanent home to tigers.

Unlike Sariska and Panna in Madhya Pradesh, where reintroduction of tigers took place within years of their population being wiped out without any other significant loss to the biodiversity necessary for the species to thrive, the new places being proposed have been without tigers for decades, and the ecosystem, including the tiger's prey base, has seen severe depletion. While relocation to Sariska and Panna focused on creating a safety net against the main cause of the disappearance of tigers from there—poaching—the reasons why tigers disappeared from the other sites haven't been adequately analysed so far. Officials point to Mukundara Hill Tiger Reserve as an example of relocation gone wrong. The reserve lost three tigers and four cubs within days in 2020, while a tigress had to be treated for injuries.

Of the four places where tigers from Ranthambore are being sought to be relocated, the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) has approved Ramgarh Vishdhari as the state's fourth tiger reserve—a notification is in the pipeline. Adjoining Ranthambore National Park, it's located in Om Birla's Bundi-Kota Lok Sabha constituency. Male tigers occasionally venture into this area, but rarely stay long. Yet, Ramgarh Vishdhari's proximity to Ranthambore on its northeast has made it an acceptable choice for a new tiger reserve. To its south is the Seljar range of Mukundara Hill, Rajasthan's third tiger reserve after Ranthambore and Sariska.

Ex-CM Raje, who is the MLA from Jhalarapattan in Jhalawar district, and her son Dushyant, MP from Jhalawar-Baran, managed to get Mukundara declared a tiger reserve in 2017 ahead of Ramgarh Vishdhari, and then shifted tigers to its Durrah range, which extends into Jhalawar, instead of Seljar range in Kota district. They succeeded in getting the NTCA's approval despite resistance from some state wildlife officials who argued that Durrah didn't have a proper prey base. Keeping a tiger couple inside a massive enclosure built in Durrah was projected as a safer bet than Seljar, where the prey base had been strengthened over years, but which also has more human population around it. The 24-hectare enclosure, however, could not save the tigers. In fact, some suspect that it became the cause of deaths by offering no space for dispersal for a tigress with newborns in the vicinity of an aggressive tiger.

"RELOCATING TIGERS HAS TO BE A SCIENTIFIC DECISION. IT TAKES YEARS TO REBUILD THE ECOSYSTEM ADEQUATELY."

There is again a plan to release a tiger or two in Durrah range, though minister Dhariwal, whose constituency is in Kota, wants tigers in Seljar first. Officials, however, suggest that sanctuaries like Kaila Devi adjoining Ranthambore, home to half-a-dozen tigers most of the time, be developed to accommodate more tigers. Another option, they say, is to remove villages from inside Sariska in order to grant it the status of a national park and increase its capacity to house 40 tigers.

As for MP Diya Kumari's pitch for Kumbhalgarh, the NTCA said tiger relocation could begin in two years if the Rajasthan government worked on its recommendations to make it suitable for tigers. Six months since that go-ahead, the Congress government hasn't taken the first step. "It is not easy to get NTCA approval for a new reserve and the state government should not let my effort go waste," says Kumari, who believes a tiger reserve in Kumbhalgarh would transform the local economy for the better by creating a tourist destination that combines the appeal of both wildlife and heritage. ■

WHERE THEY WANT TIGERS

